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## # Health & Safety

### Health and Safety

Parks in Hanoi. Photo by Aaron Joel Santos

Vietnam has been ranked one of the safest countries in the world for travellers, however it always pays to be prepared. These health and safety tips will help you travel Vietnam with greater peace of mind. Also below is a list of public and private hospitals for easy reference.

#### HEALTH TIPS FOR TRAVELLING VIETNAM

Before you go

Before traveling to Vietnam, be sure to purchase insurance

for your trip. Two months before you leave, you should also consult your doctor or local travel clinic for the latest information on health risks in Vietnam and to receive any vaccinations you may need.

Pregnant women

should consult their doctors for specialised advice. Anti-malarial drugs and many diarrhoea treatments are not completely safe during pregnancy.

If you have a medical condition or allergy of which requires particular attention, carry a doctor?s letter

with you that describes the nature of the condition and treatment needed. We also recommend you pack a medical kit with:

DEET-based insect repellent

Paracetamol or ibuprofen for pain relief

Anti-itch ointment,

such as hydrocortison

Sunscreen

Antihistamine for allergy treatment,

such as zertec, benadryl

Bacitracin for wound care

, such as neosporin

Diarrhoea treatment,

such as imodium

Some medications can be difficult to find in Vietnam:

be sure you travel with a full supply of any prescribed medicine you need.

Hospitals in Vietnam

Major cities such as

Hanoi, Danang

, and

Ho Chi Minh City

have a number of state-owned and private hospitals with English-speaking staff. While small pharmacies are common in almost any Vietnamese city, in the rural areas you may be far from the nearest pharmacy or hospital.

#### COMMON HEALTH ISSUES IN VIETNAM

Pollution in Vietnam

Air pollutants may aggravate

asthma

and

allergy

symptoms. Symptoms include scratchy throat and nasal drip. For anyone with respiratory ailments, invest in a small mask while travelling around metropolitan areas, or plan to spend more time in the countryside if possible.

Mosquito-borne diseases

The risk of contracting

malaria

is heightened in the rural highlands. Consider taking anti-malarial medication if you plan to travel to any remote destinations in Vietnam.

Dengue fever

has become increasingly problematic in Southeast Asia and occurs mostly in the Mekong Delta, including Ho Chi Minh City. With no vaccines available, the best preventive measure is to wear bug spray during the hours of sunrise and sunset.

Heat concerns

Vietnam tends to be hot and humid year round. Don't underestimate the strength of the sun.

Sunburn

can happen quickly: it's best to wear sunscreen throughout the day. Be vigilant with reapplication, especially at beachside destinations.

Dehydration

is another concern, as well as heat exhaustion, which may show up in symptoms such as headaches and irritability.

Drink plenty of water

.

Heatstroke

is a more serious consequence of overexposure to sun and may require hospital treatment. If you're feeling weak, dizzy, nauseous, and have a temperature of over 41°C, get medical help immediately.

Food-related illnesses

Traveller's diarrhoea

is a common concern when in new countries. Stick to bottled water and avoid ice in rural areas. To avoid contracting bacteria, look for restaurants with a high turnover of customers and those that prepare freshly cooked food. Generally street food in Vietnam is quite safe, but always use your own judgement when choosing from vendors. If you experience stomach upsets or diarrhoea, take rehydration salts and stay hydrated. If the problems persist, seek medical attention.

Critter bites

These are sometimes an issue when staying in hostels and other shared dormitories, and sometimes even in hotels. Seek help at the nearest clinic if you're suffering from the bites of

fleas

,

bed bugs

, and/or

lice

. Be on the lookout for

rabies

when in contact with animals, wild or domesticated. Avoid the monkeys on Cat Ba Island when touring Ha Long Bay. When jungle trekking, be wary of

ticks, leeches

and

poisonous snakes

lurking in the undergrowth. Seek medical assistance immediately if bitten.

## SAFETY TIPS FOR TRAVELLING VIETNAM

### Petty theft

Vietnam is a relatively safe country, however petty theft is a legitimate concern, especially in the big cities. Refrain from extending cameras and cellphones on busy streets and corners: most robberies are drive-by snatchings

. When taking pictures on sidewalks, keep your camera close to your body and away from the flow of traffic.

Women in particular should be warned to

keep a tight grip

on their bags and purses when walking in Ho Chi Minh City. When riding a motorcycle, place your bags in the seat compartment or hook them in the front of the bike. Bags carried around the shoulder or in bike baskets can easily be snatched.

When staying in hotels and guesthouses, place your valuables

in the safe

or lock them in your bags before leaving your room. It is a good idea in general to be mindful of your valuables, keep a close eye on your bags and not to flaunt large amounts of cash or expensive gadgets in rural areas.

Unfortunately, if you find yourself the victim of theft, little can be done by law enforcement to recover stolen belongings.

### Taxi scams

Taxi scams in Vietnam take the form of rigged meters, overcharging, confusing currency and fixed prices.

Two trusted companies you can rely on are

Mai Linh

and

Vinasun

. Both of these taxi companies have new vehicles and sealed metres, they also have a pick-up service that works in most Vietnamese towns and cities. You can look for them as soon as you land in Vietnam's international airports.

### Tourist Scams

Vietnam is constantly improving its tourism services, however there are still some agents and independent operators who flout the rules. When booking cruises on Halong Bay, always go with reputed companies. For tours around Vietnam, book with vetted travel agents as opposed to hole-in-the-wall establishments to avoid being scammed.

### For Female Travellers

Vietnam is generally a safe country to travel and female travellers will find themselves welcome. The Vietnamese are still quite conservative, so it's best to respect the local culture by not baring too much skin. Solo female travellers can expect to be approached with questions about why they are travelling alone. The enquiries are usually harmless and borne out of curiosity. Crime against women is uncommon in Vietnam. Nonetheless it's wise to not be alone on the streets late at night, and to take a taxi if you're heading back late.

### International hospitals in Vietnam

Filter by: All region

Northern

Central

Southern

Columbia Asia

No. 8, Alexandre de Rhodes, B?n Nghé, District 1, B?n Nghé, Vietnam

+84 8 3823 8888

+84 8 3823 8888

[www.columbiaasia.com/vietnam](http://www.columbiaasia.com/vietnam)

Family Medical HCMC

Diamond Plaza, 34 Le Duan, District 3, H? Chí Minh, Vietnam

+84 8 3822 7848

+84 8 3822 7859

[www.vietnammedicalpractice.com](http://www.vietnammedicalpractice.com)

FV Hospital

No. 6 Nguyen L??ng B??ng, Tân Phú, District 7, H? Chí Minh, Vietnam

+84 8 54 11 33 33

+84 8 54 11 33 34

[www.fvhospital.com/en](http://www.fvhospital.com/en)

International SOS

No.167A Nam Ky Khoi Nghia street, district 3, HCMC, Vietnam

+84 8 3824 0777

+84 8 3829 8551

[www.internationalsos.com](http://www.internationalsos.com)

Yersin International

No. 10 Truong Dinh - Ward 6 - District 3 - HCMC

+84 8 3933 66 88

+84 8 3930 46 64

[www.yersinclinic.com/](http://www.yersinclinic.com/)

Victoria Healthcare Vietnam

152 Nguyen Luon Bang, Tan Phu, District 7, HCMC, Vietnam

+84 8 3910 4545

+84 8 3910 4545

[www.victoriavn.com](http://www.victoriavn.com)

Family Medical Practice Hanoi

Van Phuc Compound, 298 Kim Ma Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi, Vietnam

+84 4 3843 0748

+84 4 3846 1750

[vietnammedicalpractice.com](http://vietnammedicalpractice.com)

Hong Ngoc Hospital

55 Yen Ninh, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi, Vietnam

+04 8 39 275 568

+04 8 39 275 568

[www.hongngochospital.vn](http://www.hongngochospital.vn)

L?Hopital Francais de Hanoi

No.1 Phuong Mai, Dong Da District, Hanoi, Vietnam

+84 4 3577 1100

+84 4 3576 4443

[www.hfh.com.vn](http://www.hfh.com.vn)

International SOS Hanoi

51 Xuan Dieu Street, Tay Ho District, Hanoi, Vietnam

+ 84 4 3934 0666

+84 4 3934 0556

[www.internationalsos.com](http://www.internationalsos.com)

Viet Duc Hospital

40 Trang Thi Street, Hanoi, Vietnam

+84 4 3825 3531

+84 4 3825 3531

[www.vietduchospital.edu.vn](http://www.vietduchospital.edu.vn)

VINMEC International Hospital

458 Minh Khai Street, Hai Ba Trung District, Hanoi, Vietnam

+84 4 3974 3556

+84 4 3974 3557

[www.vinmec.com](http://www.vinmec.com)

Family Medical Danang

96-98 Nguyen Van Linh Street, Hai Chau District, Danang, Vietnam

+84 236 3582 699

+84 236 3583 049  
www.vietnammedicalpractice.com  
Hoan My Danang Hospital  
161 Nguy n V n Linh, Th c Gi n, Q. Thanh Kh , Da Nang, Vietnam  
+84 236 3650 676  
+84 236 3650 676  
www.hoanmy.com  
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